PARTS: Added value. Faculty

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1. The move

LNU launches a **Faculty Grant Track**: a package that turns the university's scale and its international partnerships into things a researcher cannot get elsewhere in Lviv. It has four elements:

- **Professional grant office.** Managers prepare and support applications, budgets and reporting, so the researcher is responsible only for the science. LNU already has a base: the National Contact Point for Horizon Europe [6] and experience coordinating CBHE projects (UTTERLY, EU4UA) [7].
- **Grant money for time.** A share of the overhead from won grants funds a lower teaching load for the grant winners and support for their departments.
- **Mobility as part of a career.** Fellowships and joint positions through EC2U, Sheffield and Birmingham, with a guaranteed return to the home department.
- **Bridge from PhD to grant position.** Grant-funded junior and postdoctoral positions for PhD graduates, so that more of them stay at LNU.

The message to faculty: *"At LNU you teach, research and win international funding, while a professional team handles the paperwork."*

2. Why this lever

Added value is what the game is worth with a player minus what it is worth without it [1]. Our team's Value Net showed that LNU's added value for faculty comes from scale and profile: it is the largest academic employer in Lviv for the humanities and natural sciences (2,230 research and teaching staff, 372 of them doctors of science) [2] and it has its own PhD pipeline (202 students enrolled in 2024, 174 of them on state-funded places; 24 graduates stayed to work at LNU) [2]. At the same time, LNU cannot win the faculty arena on pay. The IT sector, UCU and KSE compete on individual salaries (KSE says pay is set individually at a competitive level) [3], and foreign universities offer mobility and research conditions [4]. Raising pay across 2,230 people is not realistic, and a price war would be lost.

So the move raises the other side of the offer: what the university gives a researcher besides a salary. It also links the faculty arena (F) with the grants arena (G). In 2024 research at LNU received UAH 83.0m, including UAH 19.5m from eight NRFU projects [2], but LNU was not in the top five Ukrainian universities by Horizon projects [6]. Losing researchers in F directly weakens LNU in G, and strengthening them in F strengthens the grant portfolio.

3. What changes in the game

Before: a researcher chooses an employer mostly by pay and prestige. LNU is a stable, large workplace, but it offers little that an IT company, UCU or a foreign university cannot match. Grant work is done by individual enthusiasts on top of a full teaching load, which is why LNU is strong in a few humanities and European projects (EC2U, Sheffield, Jean Monnet) [5][8] and weak in Horizon.

After: the product is a research career with time, funding support and international networks. Without LNU, its researchers would lose not only a job but also access to the EC2U alliance (LNU is a strategic partner since 2022) [5], the grant infrastructure and the route from PhD to a funded position. The IT sector cannot replace these, and UCU and Lviv Polytechnic offer them on a smaller scale or in other fields. LNU's added value for faculty rises from "a large workplace" to "a workplace with conditions for research". The pie also grows: more funded projects bring more money to the university, to partners and to students.

4. Who wins and who loses

Player	Effect	Why
Research-active faculty (F)	Win	More time for research, less bureaucracy, access to international partners. Early-career staff and humanities scholars gain most.
PhD students and graduates (F)	Win	A real path after the defence instead of leaving the university. Today only 24 graduates a year stay [2].

Player	Effect	Why
LNU students (A)	Win	Teaching based on current research, more international projects and mobility.
Faculty not active in research	Lose or neutral	Conditions become differentiated, which may cause internal tension. The track must be open to everyone who meets clear criteria.
LNU administration	Cost	The grant office and the overhead split need money before they pay back. Payback is not immediate.
Lviv Polytechnic	Small loss	It will find it harder to attract LNU staff in the humanities and natural sciences, but it keeps its lead in technical grants.
UCU, KSE, Kyiv-Mohyla (NaUKMA)	Small effect	They can still hire individuals with better pay or conditions, but cannot absorb LNU's scale. Their profiles are narrower.
IT sector, foreign universities	Little effect	They compete on money and prospects, not on grant infrastructure. The move reduces the outflow of those who value research.
Donors and partners (G)	Win	A more reliable Ukrainian partner for EC2U, Erasmus+, Jean Monnet, Sheffield and Birmingham [5][8].

5. How competitors might respond, and does the move still pay off?

Lviv Polytechnic can copy the grant office. It is the strongest player in grants (leader in Erasmus+ KA2 and Horizon in 2024) [6]. But its strength is technical fields, while the humanities and European projects, where LNU is hard to replace, stay outside its profile. **UCU** can raise pay or offer conditions to selected people, but doing this for a staff the size of LNU's is too expensive. **Kyiv-Mohyla (NaUKMA)** overlaps mainly in the humanities and social sciences and has no reason to react strongly, since no staff transfers between it and LNU are confirmed. The **IT sector and foreign universities** will hardly react, because they compete on different terms.

A co-opetition option: since UCU and NaUKMA are partners with LNU in DigiUni [9], the grant office can offer joint applications and shared support in this consortium. Rivals then become partners in the grants arena, which softens their response.

Verdict: the move still pays off. It rests on assets that rivals cannot quickly reproduce: the strategic partnership in EC2U since 2022 [5], years of CBHE coordination [7], and the humanities and European profile. Most of the cost is organisational (staff for the office and a rule for the overhead split), not new buildings or large salary increases. The sources do not prove that rivals systematically poach LNU staff, so the main benefit is lower risk of losing researchers and more funded projects, not a guaranteed result. Main risks: the office does not show visible results and internal support fades; the track is seen as unfair to non-research staff. Success can be measured by the number of grant applications and won projects (including Horizon), the number of PhD graduates who stay at LNU (24 in 2024 as the baseline), and staff retention in the humanities and natural sciences.

Sources

1. Brandenburger, A. & Nalebuff, B. (1995). The Right Game: Use Game Theory to Shape Strategy. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/1995/07/the-right-game-use-game-theory-to-shape-strategy

2. Rector's Report of Lviv University (LNU) for 2024: staff, PhD programme, research funding, NRFU projects (pp. 5-32).

3. KSE announcement on faculty recruitment (economics and finance): pay set individually at a competitive level.

4. Cedos, "Academic migration" and Cedos study on the careers of women scientists in STEM.

5. LNU, EC2U alliance page (2026): strategic partner since 2022; LNU partners Sheffield and Birmingham (#TwinforHope).

6. LNU, Horizon Europe 2024 (National Contact Point; top-5 ranking) and Erasmus+ KA2 2024 results.

7. EEAS (2023) and Ministry of Education and Science (2020) on CBHE projects; LNU International Department (UTTERLY, EU4UA).

8. LNU, University of Sheffield Ukrainian studies project (2023-2024) and LNU department report 2023 (Jean Monnet modules).

9. DigiUni consortium (Erasmus+, 2023-2027): partners LNU, UCU and NaUKMA.

Facts come from the team's Value Net fact sheets (Q1-Q4). The proposed measures are the author's own ideas, not facts.